Autopsy (Selections from)

By Donte Collins

Death Ain't Nothing but a Song

My mother moved out
of her body decided it
was no longer worthy

it couldn't contain her laughter
she couldn't obey the house
rules of human her spirit,

that young & fresh fever wanted
to call the night her dance club
wanted to try on new clothes
stay out later

my mother now wears the world
dresses herself with the tall grass
blushes her cheeks with red clay

she laughs & a forest fire awakens
she laughs & every mountain bows
to her sharp thunder she laughs
& each cicada begins to
sing last
night Saint Paul was cloaked in

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steam:
fog traveled from some distant
heat.

no, I think you've got it all wrong.
Someone must have asked my mother

to

dance

INTRODUCTION

Perhaps writer David Ferguson words will help explain how difficult it is to cope with the loss of your mother: "The magnitude and bottomlessness of the pain you feel is a testament to the love you shared. And while I don't ever expect to arrive at a point in life where I'm alright with the fact that my mother is gone, I know that I am so, so lucky to have loved and been loved that much by anyone."

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The Orphan Performs an Autopsy on the Garden

there are many ways to pull a weed
but only one will keep the garden
clean come the end of summer

your mother will be dead
***13 years - 2 months - 11 days - 7 hours* from now**

& you curse her beneath your breath. flick beaded sweat

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gathered
like pearls at the crease of your brow & continue to rip up
the earth

why does heat make the body confess what it will not do
otherwise?
drunk on july & nerve you rip handfuls of color from along
the fence
thorns like brief alarms warning your fevered temper of
what blood
will soon stain your teeth. never. ruin. your. mother's. new.
plants

your mother will be dead
***3 years - 6 months - 9 hours* from now**

why does heat make the body confess what it will not do
otherwise?
sneaking out of a house built of creaking wood can only end
with
red smeared across checkered linoleum. can only cause a
mother to
lock the doors from the outside. deadbolt & *don't*
disrespect my house
again! basement stairs & belt buckle branded—a birthmark
across
your sprouting back. see me: a field of dry &
rebellious wheat thrashing
until flaming. until ash

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your mother will be dead
***3 days - 6 hours - 14 minutes* from now**

& wants to take you to lunch. insists on giving you all your
old inhalers,
face-cream, old shoes. says *you never know. says if i died i*
wouldn't
know what to do with all of this—points—the china
cabinet, a small
museum of memories. says *we laughed a lot, too.* our faces
framed &
frozen to happy. says *if you & lamar don't know i love you,*
know now
& now she is weeping. see her: a black sky cracking,
offering water: as
if to say: forgiveness is a fertile thing—is what makes
tomorrow grow

& / just / like / that / she's / dead / a / porch / light / gone /
out / a
wind / chime / songless / sunken / into / soil / you /
untethered / 19
returning / to / an / empty / home / find / your / hands /
busy / in
an / abandoned / garden / joy / must / be / a / flower /
among / all
of / this / knotted / agony / there / are / many / ways / to /
pull / grief

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from / the / body / but / only / one / will / keep / the / boy/
alive

TRANSITION

And as you struggle to accept the grief, to give yourself grace to mourn . . . the wheels of society are working to find a new family to care for you.

Words that begin with the letter A: Autopsy . . . . Adoption

Alternate Beginning: The Game

is simple & played with my brother
in the backseat, as each home flutters
past you point & say ***yes*** or ***no***

yes, you would live there
no, you would not

maybe a home
with grass, the good kind, the shiny kind, the kind outside
the courthouse. the kind that reaches all the way to the
curb:
no dirt patches, no dead bulking brown, no yellow weeded
intruders spotting through crumbling cement, no
abandoned
sideways tricycle, rain rusted & waiting & waiting

maybe a home

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with a tree fit for five-year-old feet, a garden even, visible
from the street. maybe our newer mother will grow things.
good things. the nutritious kind. the kind that chemicals
cannot
produce. the kind that doesn't kindle or make lamar, my
older
bro, cough like he does. like a factory in his chest or a fight

maybe a home
with windows, ones you can see both in & out of, &
curtains
blue & wavy, then sometimes it'll be like you're near the
water
& river weed & sleep will come easy. unlike breath, unlike
those men with badges on their chests always upturning
the mattress
dumping out cabinets, like they searching for something
bad
something they need, something bagged & that easily
burns

maybe a home
with brick or blue plaster with ribbons tied to the railing,
maybe
they'll know we're coming, maybe they won't know where
we've been
then it'll be like we're new & nameless. a porch swing. A
welcome mat. ***yes, yes***

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i ask the man driving if adoption hurts like a needle. i ask if
lamar,
my older bro will be there too. to him my questions are
caught flies
charging the glass. he opens the window & out falls my:
yes, yes

maybe a home
with a porchlight. maybe a home
with a white fence. maybe a home
without holes. maybe a home
with fresh paint. maybe a home
without screams in the front screens
yes, yes. maybe a home
with a doorbell. maybe a home
with a door

Grief, Again

[AND STILL . . .] every black woman with grey hair is your dead mother you collapse in Walmart knees buckled at the sight of an electric scooter you wrap yourself around yourself & wail into a naked mattress you show the dean the death certificate & are allowed to stay another semester drowning would be easiest you think as rain

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draws razor thin lines down your bedroom window grief is a paper cut at every bend in your body grief shaves each bone down to a shriveled white flag you want to die but don't want to leave a mess you throw a mug across the kitchen & envy its sudden dissection every word your mother last spoke scuttles like mice in your deserted head memory is a ruptured organ memory is a ghost begging for new flesh memory taps a gun to your inner skull & demands you bring back the dead

LONG STORY SHORT

someone who is dead now taught you
how best to clean up your blood. then
how to clean up blood when it is not
your own. how to push from your elbow
properly sweep a floor, spell *c o n t i n u e*

three syllables donte, go on & like a god
or a bird, or a boy salted with grief, you
want the earth to kneel for you, want every
clock to confess its slick motive. to say,
suddenly, that death is only a joke

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the earth's biggest punchline. she's been
gone 15,840 minutes & you have felt the
godless storm of each of them, are waiting
for your mother to walk into her funeral, to
sit next to all of her children at once, to lean
into the soft of her shoulder, for her to whisper
it's okay son, i'm here now, i'm here

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AWARD HISTORY

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